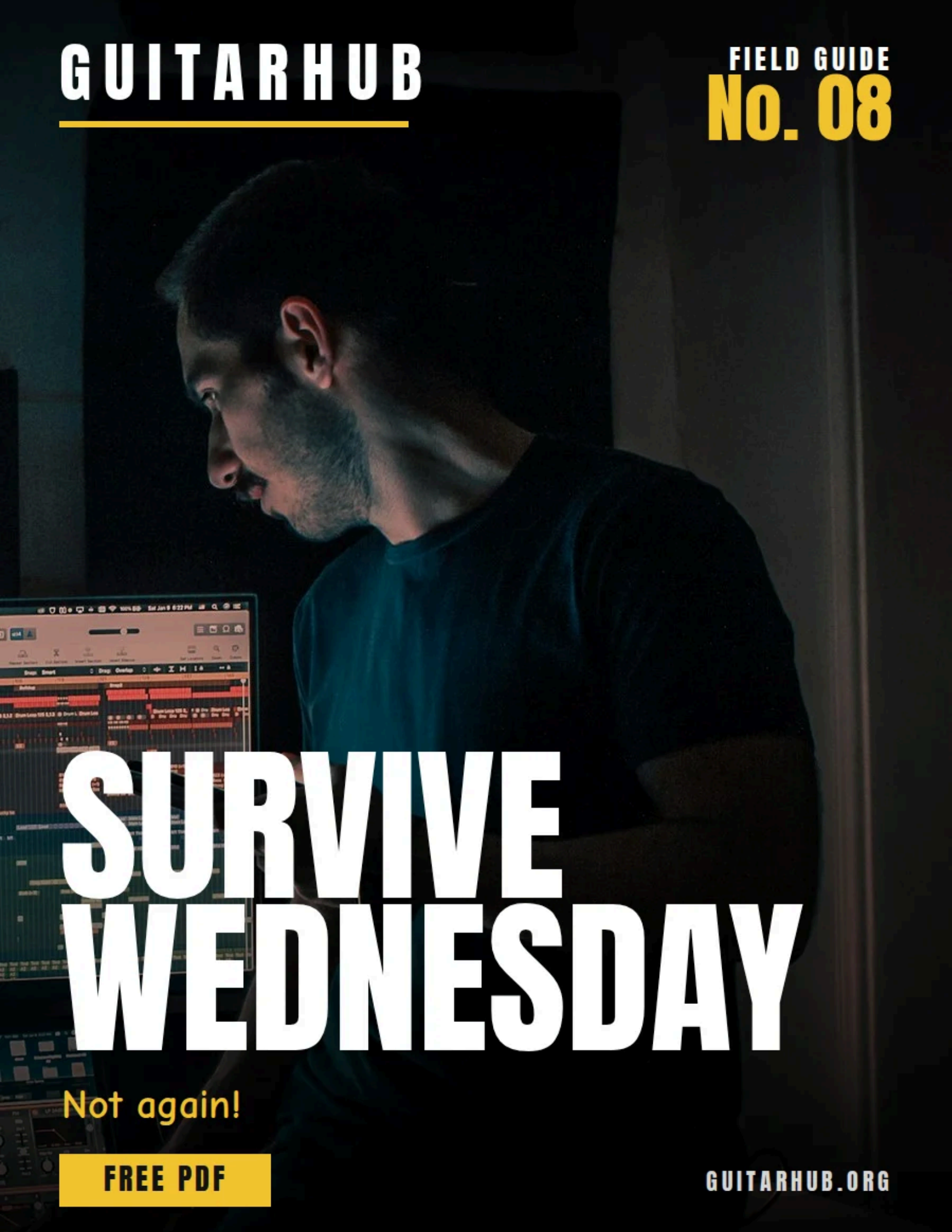


GUITARHUB

FIELD GUIDE
No. 08



SURVIVE WEDNESDAY

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A guitar practice schedule that *survives a real week*.

Built around a weekly minute total instead of a daily streak, with one session you defend, a cut order you decide in advance, and a ten-minute version that still does a job.

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A guitar practice schedule survives a real week when it is built around a weekly minute total instead of a daily streak. Pick a number of minutes you would hit in a bad week rather than a good one. Protect one anchor session at a fixed day and time and defend it the way you would defend a dentist appointment. Let every other session float. Decide in advance what gets cut when the week goes wrong, so that decision is not made at ten at night by whichever part of practice feels worst. Keep a ten-minute version that does one job properly. Then judge the week on whether the minutes landed on the thing you are trying to change — missed days included, because they happen in every real week and are not failure.

The schedule that collapses on Wednesday usually collapsed on paper, before the week started. It was designed for the week you meant to have.

This page is about the week: the minutes it holds, the one session you defend, and the order you cut things in. What goes inside a session is a different question with two different answers depending on where you are: how long to practice each day sizes a single session and says what belongs in ten, twenty-five or sixty minutes, and the intermediate practice routine gives the five blocks a session holds once the beginner gains have run out. This page is the container for both.

Why rigid daily schedules break

Thirty minutes every day at the same time describes what a settled practice looks like from the outside, which makes it a poor instruction for building one. Three things go wrong.

It cannot represent a partial day. A schedule that only knows *practiced* and *did not practice* turns a fifteen-minute Tuesday into a miss, and being marked a failure for showing up is a reliable way to stop showing up.

Every session is the same size. So the work that needs a long block — recording a full take, deciding what actually breaks, resetting a tempo ladder — never gets scheduled on purpose. It lands on whichever evening feels roomy, which is to say rarely.

It fails all at once. Miss two days and the plan is no longer the plan you agreed to, and there is no defined way back into it. Most people do not resume a broken schedule. They wait for Monday, then for the first of the month.

Design the week around a total, not a streak

Replace *thirty minutes a day* with a weekly figure: *a hundred and fifty minutes this week*. The unit of the plan becomes the week, and the day becomes a place to put minutes. A skipped Tuesday is no longer a hole; it is minutes still on the table, and minutes can move. A streak cannot move — it can only break.

Pick the number from evidence, not intention. Count what you actually did over the last three weeks, including the fifteen-minute evenings, and make the worst of the three your budget. A budget you clear is a schedule you keep. A budget set from your best week is the streak problem with extra arithmetic.

Then make the sessions unequal on purpose. A hundred and fifty minutes might be one forty-five, two twenty-fives, and the rest in tens. Expensive work goes in the long session; cheap, repeatable work goes in the short ones.

One rule keeps this from becoming an accounting exercise: minutes count only when they went to the thing you are trying to change. Twenty minutes playing what you already play well is a good evening, and it is not a deposit. Strumly's guide to [designing a practice routine](#) covers what belongs inside the blocks once the week has a shape.

Protect one anchor session

An anchor is one session a week with a fixed day, a fixed time, and a job that justifies its length. Everything else floats around it. One anchor, not three: a second is not twice the protection, it is a session you feel guilty about.

Choosing the slot

- **Fewest dependencies wins.** A slot that needs nobody else's cooperation survives more weeks than a better one that needs three people to hold their plans.
- **Earlier than feels necessary.** Sunday morning survives. Thursday at nine at night competes with a whole week of accumulated tiredness.
- **Not against something you would rather do.** A slot that makes you win an argument with yourself every week will eventually lose one.

What goes in it

The work that cannot be done in fragments. One full take of the piece, recorded and listened back. Naming the single repair target for the week. Setting or resetting a tempo ladder for the passage that is failing. Anything that needs a run-up, or that produces a decision the short sessions spend the week executing.

The rule that makes it an anchor: if exactly one session happens this week, it is this one. Which means when Wednesday comes under threat, you do not move the anchor to cover it. You let Wednesday go.

Decide the cut order before you need it

At ten at night on a bad Wednesday you will cut whatever is least pleasant, and that is almost always the repair work — the one part that changes your playing. So the order gets decided in daylight, once.

1. **New material goes first.** Starting a new song is the most expensive item in the week and the least urgent. It is also the hardest to give up, because opening something new feels like progress.
2. **Then the long warm-up.** Keep two minutes of it. A warm-up is a ramp onto the work; a twelve-minute one has quietly become the session.
3. **Then full run-throughs.** A run-through is measurement, and measurement is expensive in minutes. One a week is enough to see whether the repair is holding.
4. **Then volume on the repair target**, but never the target itself. Six attentive repetitions beat twenty distracted ones, and six fit inside a short session.

Two things never get cut: the anchor session, and the recording that makes the month comparable at the end.

Writing the order down means a bad week produces a smaller version of the same plan instead of a different plan. That is the whole trick. Plans rarely die of one bad week. They die of being improvised four weeks in a row.

Where a ten-minute day sits in the week

A ten-minute session is not a compressed full session, and the scheduling question about it is narrower than what to put in it. It is whether the ten minutes count. They do, on one condition: that the minutes came out of the week total rather than out of nowhere, so a run of short days shows up as a light week instead of as a plateau.

So log it as ten, not as a session. Four ten-minute days and one anchor is a real ninety-minute week and should be read as one. The same week recorded as five sessions reads like a productive one that somehow produced nothing, and the next decision you make from it will be the wrong one.

What those ten minutes should actually contain is the other page's question, and [how long to practice each day](#) answers it in a shape you can run. For sizes in between, the odd thirty-five a real week hands you, the [practice session builder](#) takes the minutes you have and the one thing you are fixing and returns blocks that add up to exactly that number, dropping the ones whose share came out too small to be worth starting rather than shrinking all of them.

Missed days are part of the plan

You will miss days. Work, illness, family, travel, and plain flatness. A schedule that treats those as anomalies will be wrong most weeks, and a plan that is wrong most weeks stops being consulted.

Take the same week under both designs: you practice on four days out of seven and the minutes add up to what you intended. Under a daily schedule that is three failures. Under a weekly total it is a completed week. Same playing, two verdicts, and only one is still in use next Monday.

A streak also gets more expensive the longer it runs, so a single break starts to feel like an ending rather than a Tuesday. A weekly total has nothing to break; its worst outcome is a week under budget, which is a number and not a verdict on you. The only miss that costs you the month is the one you convert into a decision to stop.

Restarting after a week you missed

Do not start the plan over. It is the most expensive response to a cheap event, and it resets the thing that took real work to build: knowing exactly what is broken and how slowly you have to play it. Assume the week cost you some tempo and none of the diagnosis.

- 1. Keep the goal.** A missed week is the worst moment to choose a new finish line. The new one looks exciting and the old one now smells of failure, which is a feeling about last week rather than a fact about the goal.
- 2. Re-take the last thing you were working on, cold.** Write down the tempo. It will be lower than where you left off. That is information about where to start, not a judgment.
- 3. Drop the ladder a few steps, not to the bottom.** Climb from the tempo you just measured, not the one you remember.

4. **Repeat the last week you completed**, not the week the calendar says you are on. A repeated week costs seven days. A restart costs the month.
5. **Do not double next week to catch up.** A double week is a heavy week, a heavy week fails on Wednesday, and that manufactures the second missed week.

It is also why a month of practice is counted in weeks of the plan rather than consecutive calendar days. The [30-day guitar challenge](#) is judged on two recordings of the same thing under the same conditions. A missed week moves the second date; it does not void the first recording.

What this looks like on paper

One week at a hundred and fifty minutes, for a player working on a single failing passage.

- **Sunday, 45 minutes — the anchor.** Full take, recorded and listened back. Name this week's repair target. Set the tempo ladder for it.
- **Tuesday, 25 minutes.** Repair target, climbing the ladder. No run-through.
- **Thursday, 25 minutes.** Repair target, then reconnect it to the section around it.
- **Two floating tens.** One repair each, on whichever two days actually exist.
- **One open 35.** Repertoire, new material, or a session that got missed. Deliberately the largest block and first on the cut list, so a bad week has somewhere to take its losses.

The bad-week version is the anchor cut to thirty minutes, two tens, and nothing else: seventy minutes, still pointed at the same passage, still ending with a tempo written down. The same plan at a smaller size, which is the property that matters.

The schedule is only a container

A week with good structure and nothing worth putting in it is still wasted. The schedule decides when you practice and how the week absorbs damage. What goes inside comes from a diagnosis: one finish line, one thing that breaks, one repair target at a time.

The [30-day breakthrough planner](#) turns one goal into four weeks and names the evidence each week has to produce — the material this schedule carries. It needs no account. If the harder question is what to work on rather than when, Strumly's guide to [practicing guitar with an AI coach](#) covers turning a vague sense that something is off into a specific answer.

Build the week from the worst version of itself. A schedule that only works on a good week has not been tested against the only kind of week you reliably get.